LATIN AMERICA

U.S. officials suspect Russia in mystery 'attacks' on diplomats in Cuba, China

The strong suspicion that Russia was behind the alleged attacks is backed by signals intelligence,

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Sept. 11, 2018, 1:42 AM PDT

By Josh Lederman, Courtney Kube, Abigail Williams and Ken Dilanian

WASHINGTON – Intelligence agencies investigating mysterious "attacks" that led to brain

injuries in U.S. personnel in Cuba and China consider Russia to be the main suspect, three U.S. officials and two others briefed on the investigation tell NBC News.

The suspicion that Russia is likely behind the alleged attacks is backed up by evidence from communications intercepts, known in the spy world as signals intelligence, amassed during a lengthy and ongoing investigation involving the FBI, the CIA and other U.S. agencies. The officials declined to elaborate on the nature of the intelligence.

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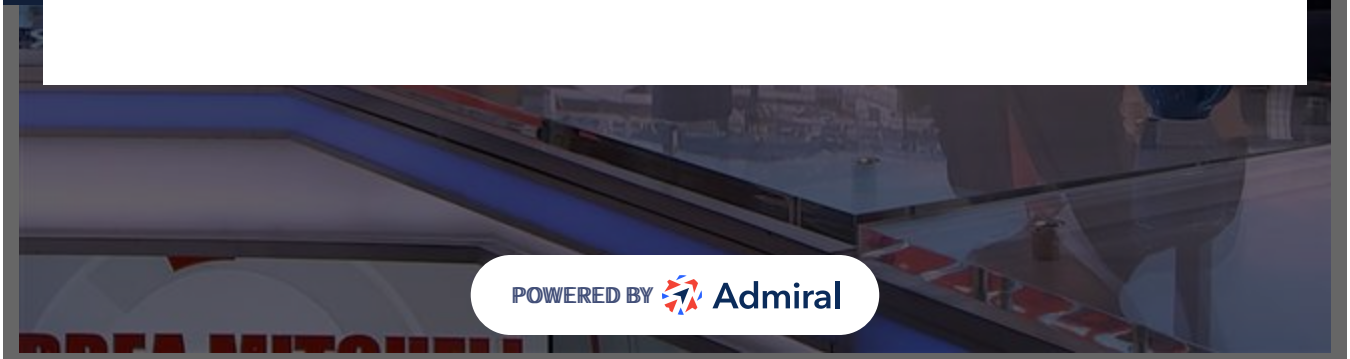

Russia suspected in mystery 'attacks'

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Since last year, the U.S. military has been working to reverse-engineer the weapon or weapons used to harm the diplomats, according to Trump administration officials, congressional aides and others briefed on the investigation, including by testing various devices on animals. As part of that effort, the U.S. has turned to the Air Force and its directed energy research program at Kirtland Air Force Base in New Mexico, where the military has giant lasers and advanced laboratories to test high-power electromagnetic

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Intelligence agencies investigati to brain injuries in U.S. personnel sia to be the main suspect, U.S. officials tell @NBCNews. nbcnews.to/2CLCZgR

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It is fair to ask why NBC would lend itself to such a dangoeorus

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and foreign capitals and calls for an immediate, concerted response, especially as President Donald Trump faces continued questions about his willingness to challenge Russia and President Vladimir Putin.

Russian government officials di o requests for comment.

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In a statement, State Department spokeswoman Heather Nauert said, "The investigation is ongoing. We have made no determination on who or what is responsible for the health attacks."

The Office of the Director of National Intelligence declined to comment.

After initial publication of this story, Cuban officials blasted it as irresponsible via Twitter. Carlos de Cossio, director general of the Cuban Foreign Ministry's U.S. Department, tweeted, "Cuba does not act and does not allow anyone to act against the diplomats of any country in its territory." Cuban ambassador to the U.S. Jose Ramon Cabanas said it was "painful to see how NBC News echoes others to mount speculation without evidence, using

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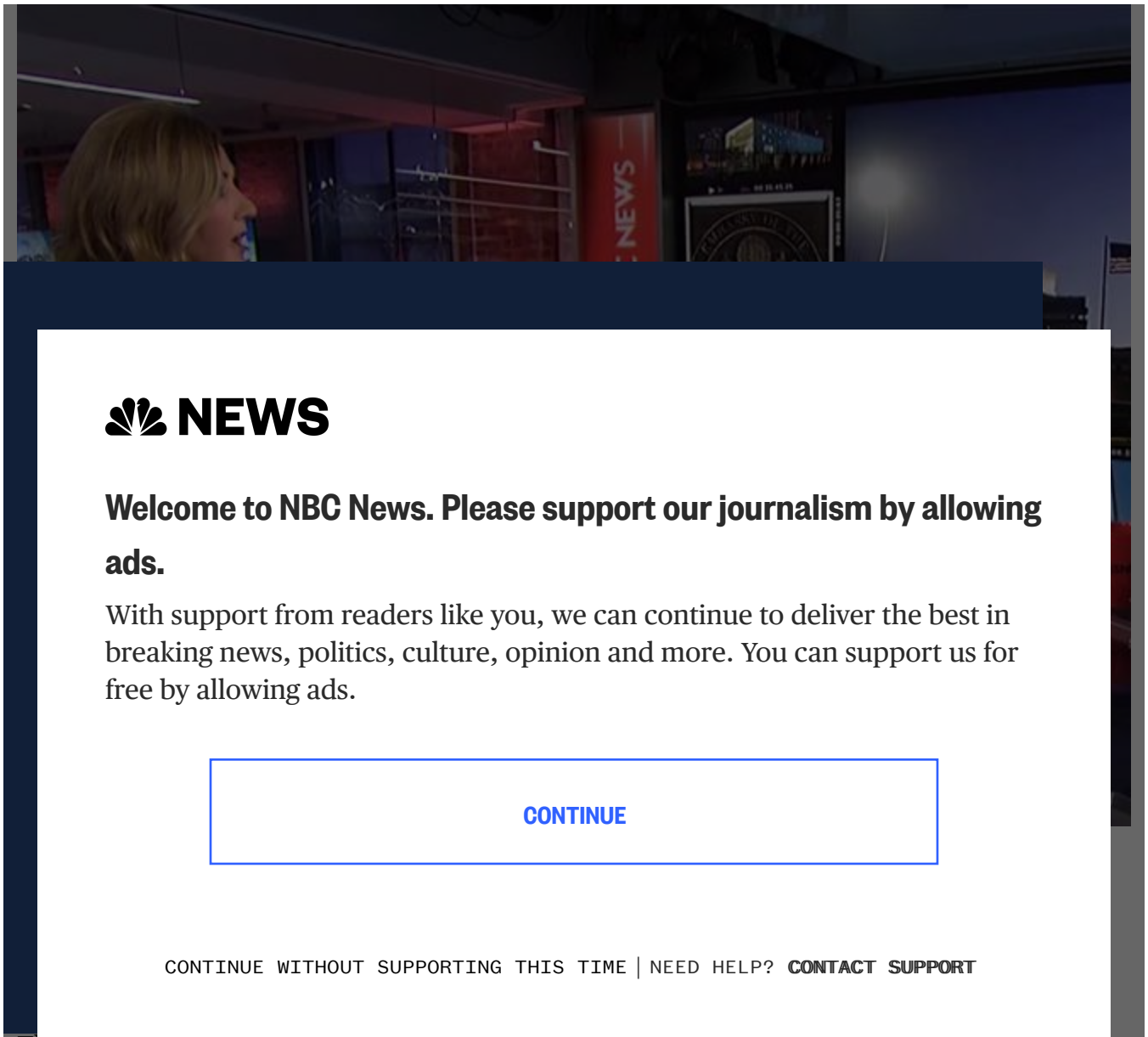

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possibility that the Cuban intelligence services may have offered the Russians some level of cooperation or tacit consent. Russian intelligence agencies operate in force in Cuba, as do Chinese spies, officials say.

Cuba's government has repeate f or involvement in attacks on Americans in Cuba, and has argued there is no evidence the attacks even took place. The U.S. maintains that whoever perpetrated the attacks, Cuba bears responsibility for failing to protect U.S. diplomats on Cuban soil.

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Although the U.S. has never disclosed their identities, officials tell NBC News that in

addition to State Department diplomats, the victims include multiple CIA officers, at least one member of the U.S. military, and representatives of other agencies.

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State Department medical officials. U.S. experts attending a neurotrauma conference in Toronto were linked in by videoconference as Penn physicians presented their most recent technical findings. But the summit ended with no new medical revelations.

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In response to the incidents, th year issued a travel notice urging all Americans to stay away from Cuba and sharply reduced the number of U.S. diplomats posted to its embassy in Havana.

By September 2017, it appeared the attacks had stopped. But then new incidents were reported in April and May of 2018, leading to two new confirmed cases.

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incident told NBC News.

Around the same time, in May, the State Department disclosed that a worker posted to the U.S. Consulate in Guangzhou, China, had also reported unexplained sounds and then been diagnosed with brain injury an the Cuba cases. It's unclear how firmly U.S. evidence indicating Russia was behind the Cuba cases extends to China, where the investigation is still in the early stages.

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In the meantime, the United States still has found no way to mitigate the risk for diplomats posted to Cuba or China. State Department officials tell NBC News that in the last few

weeks, the State Department started granting additional "incentive pay" to entice diplomats to serve in Havana despite the risk and the fact that because of the danger, they cannot bring their families.

Julia Ainsley contributed.

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